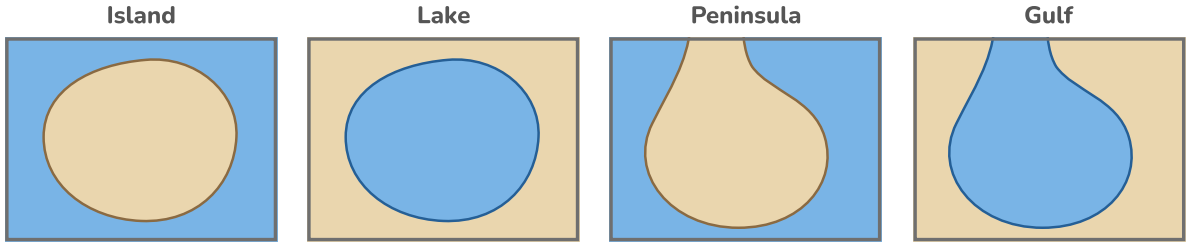
MAKING THE TRAYS

Name: ..... **Date:** .....

An adult sheet, not a worksheet: how to build the land and water form trays at home and how to present them in the Montessori way before any paper comes out.



1 WHAT YOU NEED

Two shallow trays or plastic food containers of the same size for each pair, air-dry clay or plasticine, a jug of water, and a few drops of blue food coloring. Ten trays cover all five pairs, but two trays and one pair at a time is enough to start.

2 MAKE THE PAIR

Press clay into the first tray in the shape of the land form, smoothing it up the sides so water cannot run underneath. Build the second tray as the exact negative: where the first tray has clay, the second has an empty channel, and where the first is empty, the second is clay. Let both dry, then pour colored water into the empty spaces.

3 FIRST PRESENTATION

Bring one pair to the table. Say the names as you touch the water: “This is an island. This is a lake.” Let the child pour the water from a small jug and sail a boat around the island with a finger. Do not explain, and do not ask questions yet.

4 SECOND PERIOD

Once the child has handled the trays a few times, ask for the forms: “Show me the island. Show me the lake.” Mix the order. If the child hesitates, go back to naming for another day.

5 THIRD PERIOD

Point and ask “What is this?” Only now is the child naming the form. Add the definition in words once the answer comes easily, and only then bring the worksheets in this set.

6 ORDER AND PACING

Island and lake, then peninsula and gulf, then cape and bay, then isthmus and strait, then archipelago and system of lakes. One new pair a week is plenty. Keep the earlier pairs on the shelf so the child can go back to them.

7 WHAT TO WATCH FOR

A child who names the whole tray instead of the form, a form taught without its partner, and clay pressed too thin at the rim so the water seeps underneath. Both trays of a pair hold water: in one it fills the middle, in the other it runs all the way around.

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